SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

DIGITAL MARKETING: INNOVATIVE STRATEGY FOR SUSTAINABILITY AMONG SMEs IN BUENASCAR

A Thesis Presented To
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College of Business Management and Accountancy

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Major in Marketing

By

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

		Pages
	TITLE PAGE	i
	TABLE OF CONTENTS	ii
	ABSTRACT	iii
	LIST OF TABLES	v
	LIST OF FIGURES	vi
CHAPTER:		
1	**THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE**	1
	1.1 Background of the study	1
	1.2 Review of Related Literature	4
	1.3 Theoretical Framework	19
	1.4 Schematic Diagram	22
	1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study	23
	1.6 Hypothesis	24
	1.7 Definition of Terms	25
2	**RESEARCH METHODOLOGY**	27
	2.1 Research Design	27
	2.2 Research Locale	27
	2.3 Research Respondents	28
	2.4 Research Instrument	31
	2.5 Research Ethical Standards	33
	2.6 Data Gathering Procedure	36
	2.7 Data Analysis Plan and Procedure	38

SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA
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College Of Business Management and Accountancy
ABSTRACT

TITLE: DIGITAL MARKETING: INNOVATIVE STRATEGY FOR SUSTAINABILITY AMONG SMEs IN BUENASCAR

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QUANTITATIVE RESEARCH

I. OBJECTIVES

This study seeks to investigate Digital Marketing as an Innovative Strategy for sustainability among SMEs in BUENASCAR, Agusan del Norte. It seeks to assess the profile of SMEs based on their years of operation, number of employees, and digital capabilities; identify the digital marketing strategies they employ; and determine the impact of these strategies on their sustainability performance.

II. METHODOLOGY

The study will use a quantitative research design with a structured survey questionnaire as the main data-gathering tool. Descriptive statistics—frequency and percentage—will be use to summarize the SME demographic profile, specifically years in business, number of employees, and digital capabilities. The weighted mean will measure the level of digital marketing strategies and the degree of sustainability base on the Key Performance Indicators (KPIs). Pearson's correlation coefficient will be employed to determine the relationship between digital marketing strategies and SMEs' sustainability.

III. FINDINGS

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IV. RECOMMENDATIONS

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KEYWORDS: XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX

LIST OF TABLES

Table		Pages
1	Profile of the Respondents	29

LIST OF FIGURES

Table		Pages
1	Schematic Diagram	22

CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

Background of the Study

In today's rapid technological evolution, the business endeavor continues to evolve at an unprecedented rate. The accelerated pace of technological advancement is transforming the way organizations operate, communicate, and innovate, demanding continuous adaptation to remain competitive (Ta & Lin, 2023) However, despite these fast advancements, many Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) still face significant challenges in adapting to digital marketing practices (Sharabati et al., 2024). This struggle is often caused by limited financial and technical resources, resistance to change, and a lack of expertise in operating digital tools and platforms (Yuwono et al., 2024). Such limitations place SMEs at a disadvantage, particularly in an environment where digitalization has become an essential factor of competitiveness and long-term growth (May et al., 2025).

In a recent study conducted in our neighboring city of Butuan, (Alerta et al., 2023) revealed that SMEs are increasingly recognizing the importance of innovative marketing and technology-driven business practices as essential components of their overall innovation capacity. Their findings show that enterprises demonstrating strong appreciation for innovation exhibit higher levels of marketing transformation and competitiveness, emphasizing the crucial role of modern, digitally driven marketing strategies in sustaining business performance. As determined by (Olazo, 2022) years in business, workforce size, and digital capabilities are crucial factors in ensuring SMEs' adaptability for digital transformation, such as digital marketing. The Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) defines a small enterprise as one with 10-99 employees, and a medium enterprise consists of 100-199 employees.

SMEs are classified under the Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprise (MSME) sector, which collectively belongs to the private business enterprise category. These businesses are independently owned and operated, contributing significantly to employment generation and local economic development (DTI,

2024; PIDS, 2022). According to the Philippine Statistics Authority's (PSA) List of Establishments for the year 2023, there were 1,246,373 business enterprises in the Philippines, with 1,241,733 (99.63%) being Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs). Republic Act 10644, or the Go Negosyo Act, mandates the creation of Negosyo centers across the country to help grow the small and medium enterprise sector. SMEs play a crucial role in economic and social development. They contribute significantly to revenue generation of LGUs, job creation, and the provision of essential goods and services within the communities (R. P. Silva et al., 2022).Their sustainability directly influences local economic stability and community welfare (Larona, 2024).

Yet, in an increasingly digital economy, traditional marketing methods alone are no longer sufficient to ensure business continuity (Gabelaia & Tchelidze, 2022) and failure to adapt to digital marketing strategies could hinder SMEs' potential for success and even threaten their very survival. Bruce et al. (2023) stated that the lack of digitalization in modern businesses negatively affects their online sales turnover, flexibility, and competitiveness in the era of digital transformation. Naibaho et al., (2025) defined digital marketing as the application of digital technologies to achieve marketing objectives through digital media and platforms such as social media, search engine optimization (SEO), email marketing, and mobile advertisements. Digital marketing presents itself as an innovative and cost-effective solution for this problem (Jung & Shegai, 2023). It has become an essential tool for businesses to expand their reach, engage with customers, and improve growth performance.

Astoriano et al., (2022) noted that businesses use digital channels to engage with present and prospective consumers for customer satisfaction, such as search engine optimization, social media marketing, email, and website ads marketing, and added that SMEs can expand their audience reach, strengthen customer engagement, and enhance growth performance without requiring massive costs.

Based on (May et al., 2025)This approach proves to be relevant and effective in response to the increasing market demands for more responsible and future-oriented business practices.

These tools provide accessible and adaptable means for businesses to compete effectively in the modern marketplace and even gain an advantage against competitors in the market. Atieno, (2022) stated that SMEs can use digital marketing technologies to take advantage of unique business opportunities and achieve a competitive advantage. Together, the reviewed literature clearly shows that digital marketing directly supports SME sustainability by expanding market reach, strengthening customer relationships, improving operational efficiency, and enhancing long-term competitive resilience. As SMEs integrate digital tools into their marketing practices, they gain greater adaptability, stronger performance outcomes, and the capacity to sustain growth in an increasingly digital and competitive business environment. Given this context, this study seeks to determine if digital marketing is an innovative strategy for sustainability among SMEs in BUENASCAR. The rationale of this study centers on the growing need for SMEs to adopt digital marketing as a crucial driver of competitiveness and sustainability. Although SMEs significantly contribute to economic development, many struggle to adapt to digital transformation due to limited resources (Kahveci, 2025). This creates a gap in sustaining their operations in an increasingly digital marketplace. Studies show that insufficient use of digital tools weakens SME sustainability (Rahman et al., 2025). However, digital marketing provides innovative approaches that strengthen growth, customer engagement and satisfaction as well as audience reach (Tochukwu Ignatius et al., 2024; Ijomah et al., 2024). It also enhances resilience in changing economic conditions (Usmany et al., 2024).

Therefore, this study aims to examine how digital marketing functions as an innovative strategy that supports the sustainability of SMEs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. It highlights how embracing digital innovation is not merely an option but a necessity for achieving sustainability and ensuring long-term business continuity, as based on the IDC-Microsoft survey (2020), which states 88% of Philippine business

leaders say innovation is no longer an option, but a necessity, highlighting that businesses must digitalize, or else face being left behind. By recognizing the indispensable role of digital marketing, SMEs will be able to transform challenges into opportunities and secure their relevance and resilience in today's competitive digital economy.

This study holds significant relevance for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) as it offers valuable insights into the role of digital marketing as an innovative strategy for achieving business sustainability. By effectively implementing key digital marketing practices—such as social media marketing, mobile marketing, email marketing, and search engine optimization—SMEs can enhance their market visibility, foster stronger customer relationships, and strengthen their operational resilience amid the dynamic and evolving digital economy.

For consumers, the study underscores how businesses specifically SMEs can leverage digital channels to deliver more accessible, personalized, and efficient services may, thereby improving customer satisfaction and engagement.

The findings are also pertinent to stakeholders, including business owners, policymakers, and development agencies, as they highlight strategic approaches that can promote competitiveness, stimulate innovation, and contribute to sustainable economic growth within local enterprises. This study is also significant to the College of Business, Management, and Accountancy, particularly for the BSBA Marketing Management program of Saint Michael College of Caraga. It provides meaningful insights into how digital marketing functions as an innovative tool that shapes modern business practices and sustainability strategies. The findings support the department’s academic goals by strengthening students’ understanding of real-world digital marketing applications, especially in the context of local SMEs. This research can enhance curriculum development, encourage evidence-based learning, and deepen students’ analytical skills as future marketing professionals. Ultimately, it reinforces the program’s commitment to

producing graduates who are equipped with relevant, competitive, and industry-responsive knowledge in the field of marketing and business sustainability.

Furthermore, this research provides a meaningful contribution to the academic discourse of students in exploring digital marketing and sustainability, offering a structured framework that can inform both theoretical understanding and practical application. Finally, for future researchers, the study serves as a valuable reference and foundation for further exploration into the integration of digital innovation and sustainable business strategies, particularly within the context of SMEs operating in emerging economies.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

This part presents a review of studies related to the topic Digital Marketing: Innovative Strategy for Sustainability among SMEs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. The purpose of this review is to understand how previous researchers discussed digital marketing, digital capabilities, and sustainability, and how these ideas support the current study. Farid et al., (2025) shows that digital marketing has become an important tool for small and medium enterprises (SMEs) to survive and grow in an increasingly competitive business environment. It allows businesses to promote their products, connect with customers, and expand their market reach using affordable online platforms (Ijomah et al., 2024). Studies have also emphasized that the success of digital marketing depends on the digital capabilities of the business, including internet access and devices used to adapt to technological changes (Olazo, 2025).

In addition, literature highlights that when SMEs effectively apply digital marketing, they experience improvements in growth performance, customer satisfaction, and overall sustainability (Dyatmika et al., 2024); Mou et al., 2022). However, there are still limited studies focusing on how SMEs in local areas such as Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in using digital marketing for sustainability. This research aims to fill that gap by analyzing how SMEs in these municipalities use digital marketing as an innovative strategy to achieve sustainable business performance.

Digital Marketing

Digital marketing is the application of digital technologies to achieve marketing objectives through digital media and platforms (Naibaho et al., 2025). Digital marketing has emerged as a transformative strategy that empowers SMEs to competes effectively in both local and global markets. Chan, (2025) highlighted that digital marketing initiatives, particularly social media platforms, have significantly strengthened the competitiveness and visibility of small enterprises within the Philippines. Through cost-efficient tools such as search engine optimization (SEO), social media marketing, mobile marketing, and email marketing, SMEs can enhance visibility, attract new customers, and strengthen relationships with existing ones. Dwivedi et al., (2021) affirmed that allocating budget in employing diverse online marketing strategies helps SMEs to maximize customer engagement and improve brand awareness while maintaining affordability. These strategies allow businesses to operate beyond geographic constraints and reach their target audiences more efficiently. Luz, (2025) observed that the use of digital platforms enables small businesses to extend their market reach beyond local boundaries, driving customer interaction and sales growth.

Moreover, digital marketing enables SMEs to collect data-driven insights that inform decision-making and customer engagement practices. Saura et al., (2023) emphasized that data-driven strategies in digital marketing empower SMEs to make informed marketing decisions and develop stronger relationships with customers. By integrating these tools into their overall marketing systems, SMEs can foster innovation, enhance growth performance, and expand market reach, all of which contribute to their long-term competitiveness. Paul et al., (2024) concluded that mobile-based and digital strategies enhance SMEs' innovation capacity and ensure business resilience in a dynamic digital economy.

Social Media Marketing

Social media marketing involves using online platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok to promote products and engage with consumers (Santos et al., 2024), he also discovered that Filipino firms use social media to strengthen customer relationships, boost sales, and maintain cost-effective brand communication. Similarly, (Marolt et al., 2022) explained that social media marketing enhances brand recognition and fosters customer loyalty through continuous interaction. Juniarti & Omar, (2021) findings indicate that SMEs that actively promote products on social media platforms increase brand visibility and are more likely to attract customer interest and sales. Ellyawati et al., (2023) shows that SMEs that consistently reply to comments and messages build stronger customer relationships and higher engagement levels. Consistently, (Lim & Rasul, 2022) results indicate that a strong social media presence significantly raises brand awareness and encourages customer engagement that results to reach wider, targeted audiences which leads to increased traffic and sales when campaigns are well-managed., improving SMEs' public profile. Rahamn, (2023) stated that SMEs invest in social media marketing to improve market reach. Meanwhile (Kamithi Rosemary Mugure, 2022) concluded that through social media, firms can acquire valuable insights about their customers and use them to improve their marketing decisions, which will also improve the overall performance of a business, emphasizing the importance of social media marketing for SMEs' innovative marketing approach.

Mobile Marketing

Ave Msuya, (2022) define mobile marketing as using smartphones, tablets, and other mobile devices to reach consumers through SMS, applications, and mobile advertisements. Denga & Rakshit, (2022) reported that mobile-based campaigns increase customer response rates and brand awareness, making them ideal for small enterprises. Deel, (2023) indicate that SMS and app notifications help SMEs

quickly reach customers and generate prompt responses to promotions, and added that content optimized for mobile devices yields higher click and conversion rates, making campaigns more effective for SMEs.

Hussain & Aziz, (2022) highlighted that business owners can design their own marketing content using mobile devices like smartphones or tablets while also engaging with them. Quraishi et al., (2025) shows that easier mobile access allows customers to interact more frequently with SME offers, increasing overall engagement. In a Philippine context, (Yum & Yoo, 2023) highlighted that local SMEs adopting mobile advertising experience greater customer satisfaction and real-time engagement. Fuad et al., (2023) Findings show that SMEs leveraging mobile marketing observe higher customer responsiveness and increased sales in short-term campaigns. Consequently, (Eze et al., 2021; Haji et al., 2024) found that mobile marketing has brought positive impacts on the performance of businesses in terms of brand visibility and growth performance.

Email Marketing

Email marketing involves sending promotional or relationship-building messages directly to customers via email. Mustaqeem et al., (2024) stated that email campaigns remain one of the most effective and affordable digital marketing tools that help SMEs sustain engagement by delivering personalized content that strengthens customer relationships. Email marketing allows SMEs to communicate with their customer directly, enabling them to easily give updates, product offers, and information that can encourage repeat purchases. Umunna, (2021) found out that tracking open and click rates helps SMEs refine messaging and improve return on investment for marketing.

Additionally, (Pleno & Reclusado, 2024) results show that structured email campaigns keep customers informed and encourage repeat engagement, while ongoing email communication nurtures customer relationships and trust, supporting retention. Sharma et al., (2022) discussed that personalized emails increase perceived relevance, boosting customer engagement and satisfaction. Consequently,

(Lorente-Páramo et al., 2021; Dr. Atul B. Tekade & Mr. Sushil R. Sahare, 2025) stated that email marketing is effective for SMEs as this delivers customized messages to a specific group of customers, which enhances their marketing efforts. Likewise, (Ghufrony et al., 2024) concluded that businesses leveraging email marketing experience improved customer loyalty and higher conversion rates due to its cost-efficient communication structure. Rahman et al., (2025) emphasized that the effectiveness of email marketing is not only applicable to its consumers but also to the firm's employees, as Email marketing is both cost-efficient and easy to operate.

Website ads Marketing

Website ads marketing refers to the use of online display ads and paid search placements on websites to promote a business and attract potential customers. Bayer et al., (2020) explained that website ads marketing significantly improves business growth performance by increasing sales and long-term firm value. Website ads also create measurable positive responses from customers, as (van Ewijk et al., 2021) found that display ads placed on websites generate noticeable engagement from customers leading to sales lift. Similarly, (Jabeen et al., 2024) emphasized that combining website display ads with paid search engine optimization (SEO) leads to improve visibility and higher customer engagement and leads to a higher purchase intention, making website ads a strong driver of consumer engagement and growth performance. Hervet & Guitart, (2022) added that effective display ads on websites increases clicks and conversions, especially when visuals and messages are well-designed.

Finally, (Sharma et al., 2022) noted that consumers respond more positively to relevant online ads, which strengthens their intention to purchase and boosts overall business performance. These findings show that website ads marketing provides SMEs with a powerful, cost-effective way to expand, engage with customers, and enhance competitiveness in the digital marketplace.

Search Engine Optimization (SEO)

SEO refers to the process of improving a website's visibility on search engines to attract more organic traffic. Sechele et al., (2024) emphasized that SEO enables small businesses to rank higher in search results, increasing traffic and conversion rates without significant advertising costs. Ahmad et al., (2022) findings revealed that SEO practices bring more organic visitors to SME websites, providing a steady source of potential customers. Website ads or social media pages are optimized for search engines (Respati Dewi et al., 2024), by using trendy keywords strategically, SMEs can make their business easier to find online (Akbar & Betrand Sinaga, 2023). Hoo et al., (2023) further shows that higher search rankings attract more qualified visitors, which increases the likelihood of conversions and sales for SMEs. Ingman, (2023) emphasized that choosing relevant keywords helps small businesses appear in the right searches, improving their online discoverability. Ilma Amelia Safitri et al., (2025) justified that optimizing websites and social media pages through relevant keywords helps strengthen a company's digital footprint in promoting their marketing content and brand recognition. Mou et al., (2022) added that effective SEO practices not only help SMEs build long-term credibility and visibility in competitive online environments but also help in improving sales performance. Maharani et al., (2023) stated that SEO is particularly beneficial for SMEs that operate on a limited budget but still aim to compete with larger businesses in the digital space.

Sustainability Key Performance Indicators

Sustainability in business refers to the firm's ability to achieve long term growth and stability while adapting to market changes. For SMEs, it reflects how effectively they maintain performance and competitiveness over time. This study measures sustainability through four key indicators, as stated by (Lance Astoriano et al., 2022) which are growth performance, customer satisfaction, customer engagement, and audience reach. Growth performance, which represents business expansion and financial progress, customer satisfaction and engagement, which reflects loyalty and long-term relationships, and

audience reach, which shows the firm's ability to attract and connect with current and new customers. Together, these factors determine how digital marketing supports lasting business success (Gao et al., 2023). The effective adoption of digital marketing practices significantly contributes to the sustainability of SMEs. Kahveci, (2025) emphasized that digital transformation enables small enterprises to adapt quickly to evolving market trends, ensuring their long-term sustainability in competitive environments. By leveraging online platforms, firms can achieve consistent growth, expand market reach, and improve customer relationship. Atienza et al. (2024) highlighted that the integration of digital tools allows SMEs to operate efficiently while maintaining affordability, thereby strengthening long-term business stability. Enhanced customer engagement through personalized digital communication that strengthens brand trust and loyalty. Santos-Jaén et al., 2023) emphasized that direct online interaction through digital marketing channels deepens customer relationships and fosters sustainable loyalty within competitive markets.

Furthermore, (Bindeeba et al., 2025) found that the use of integrated digital marketing strategies not only enhances customer satisfaction but also contributes to the productivity of an enterprise in terms of financial performance. Aileen Martinez-Alba & Montaño, (2025) further noted that Philippine SMEs adopting digital marketing demonstrate increased in revenue generation and improved market adaptability. These outcomes collectively promote long-term business resilience and sustainability, enabling firms to remain competitive in changing market conditions. (Hassan et al., 2024) observed that digital marketing supports SME resilience by building innovation-driven adaptability and responsiveness to market shifts. In essence, digital marketing not only supports short-term profitability but also fosters the continuous development necessary for sustainable success. Cueto et al., (2022) asserted that technology-driven business models among Philippine SMEs strengthen both sustainability and community-level economic stability.

Growth Performance

Growth serves as one of the most essential indicators of sustainability, reflecting an SME's ability to expand operations, increase profitability, and enhance market position over time. Wu et al., (2024) Results show that digital marketing strategy adoption is linked to improved competitiveness and better performance outcomes for firms in terms of inquiries and purchase interests. demonstrates how effectively a business converts its resources, innovation, and digital efforts into measurable performance outcomes. In today's competitive environment, SMEs that strategically utilize digital marketing experience faster and more consistent growth. Saad Malik et al., (2024) found that SMEs adopting digital marketing report measurable increases in sales and business growth. Also, (Qalati et al., 2022) found that firms adopting digital marketing platforms achieved higher sales due to improved market reach and customer satisfaction. Similarly, (Pleno, 2023) revealed that businesses in the Philippines that leverage online promotion channels showed steady increases in revenue and market reach, emphasizing the direct relationship between digital integration and business expansion. Nafis Fuad et al., (2024) shows that digital channels enable SMEs to enter new customer segments and geographic markets more easily.

Moreover, (Guillen & Lim, 2023) highlighted that digital transformation enhances scalability enabling SMEs to sustain growth despite limited physical resources. Beyond financial performance, growth also encompasses a firm's capacity to adapt to shifting consumer preferences and market trends. Su et al., (2023) noted that digital tools help small businesses identify and respond to emerging demands, ensuring continued relevance and innovation. In addition, (Amin et al., 2025) concluded that data-driven digital marketing allows SMEs to make informed decisions, refine strategies, and maintain steady expansion even amid market disruptions. Collectively, these findings affirm that consistent growth fueled by effective digital marketing adoption reflects not just financial success but also long-term business sustainability.

Customer Satisfaction

Customer satisfaction is the extent to which a business fulfills customer expectations, promoting loyalty and repeat engagement (Adam et al., 2020). It serves as a vital indicator of sustainability because it reflects how well SMEs meet customer expectations and maintain long-term loyalty. Mohammed Saif, (2025) indicate that SMEs using digital channels respond faster to customers, which raises customer satisfaction. Marolt et al., (2022) Results signified that timely online communication improves trust and perceived service quality among SME customers, while easily accessible product and service information online improves customer experience and satisfaction. In the digital era, maintaining high satisfaction levels is closely tied to a firm's ability to engage customers through personalized and responsive online strategies. Maduwinarti et al., (2025) highlighted those consistent digital interactions, particularly through social media and email, allow small firms to deliver timely, tailored communication that improves customer experience and retention. Similarly, (Paul-Mikki Ewim et al., 2024) noted that customer-centric digital practices not only increase satisfaction but also enhance trust and positive brand perception among SMEs' client bases.

Furthermore, integrating feedback mechanisms and analytics tools helps SMEs monitor performance and identify service improvements. Pleno & Reclusado, 2024) found that Philippine SMEs utilizing digital review systems and chat-based customer support experienced higher satisfaction scores and repeat business. Castagna et al., (2020) also confirmed that satisfied customers are more likely to advocate for brands online, creating a ripple effect that sustains reputation and business stability. Collectively, these findings establish that customer satisfaction achieved through strategic digital marketing engagements is essential to ensuring SME sustainability and continued competitiveness.

Customer engagement

Kamyabi et al., (2025) emphasize that digital marketing strengthens customer engagement; they also highlight that engagement becomes more frequent when strategies are aligned with employees' organizational roles. Kaur & Kapil, (2023) further explain that understanding customer engagement in the digital landscape helps businesses build deeper relationships and long-term loyalty. Alhidayatullah, (2024) adds that mobile marketing and social media marketing, together with SEO, significantly shape engagement, noting that consumers respond more actively when brands deliver personalized and relevant content through accessible mobile channels. Vinerean & Opreana, (2021) reinforce this by showing that engagement involves emotional and behavioral responses that marketers and that active digital interaction (reactions, comments, inquires) deepens customer relationships and increases engagement metrics.

Atieno, (2022) added that SMEs must address quick replies and digital customer service to improve engagement and customer satisfaction for digital strategies to be effective. Finally, (Kurniawan Akbar, 2022) demonstrate how firms successfully increase customer engagement and purchase intention by maximizing digital marketing channels through the visibility of online activities and consistent communication that strengthen customer relationship. Together, these studies show that customer engagement is a vital component of digital marketing and plays a central role in sustaining business performance, resulting in an essential variable in understanding SME sustainability.

Audience Reach

Audience reach reflects the ability of SMEs to expand their visibility and connect with wider market segments, and in this context, through digital channels. It measures how effectively firms use online tools to engage potential customers and establish brand presence beyond traditional boundaries. In today's digital economy, extending audience reach is vital for sustaining competitiveness and growth. Wicaksono & Sudarmiatin, (2025) explained that the use of diverse digital platforms like coordinated digital campaigns (SEO, social, ads) increases visibility for SMEs and allows SMEs to strengthen brand awareness and attract

audiences across various demographics. Likewise, (Vrontis et al., 2022) found that small firms adopting multi-channel digital strategies, such as social media and search engine optimization, achieved greater market penetration and customer conversion rates.

Moreover, digital marketing facilitates engagement in previously unreachable markets by removing geographic barriers. Bryan Givan & Budhi Hery Pancasilawan, (2025) observed that the use of online advertising enables SMEs to interact with global audiences at minimal cost, improving their chances of market expansion. Olazo, (2023) supported this by noting that Filipino SMEs leveraging social and mobile marketing tools saw a rise in both local and overseas customer inquiries. Beyond visibility, audience reach also relates to building meaningful connections. Sabihaini et al., (2021) highlighted that sustained posting and ad scheduling keep businesses visible, helping maintain audience reach over time, adding that consistent engagement across platforms fosters familiarity and trust, which ultimately translates into brand loyalty and sustained growth. Collectively, these findings indicate that digital marketing serves as a strategic pathway for SMEs to extend audience reach, enhance engagement, and strengthen their position in an increasingly interconnected marketplace.

Small to medium-sized enterprise (SME)

Small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) are widely recognized as essential drivers of economic growth and social development. Koporcic et al., (2025) highlights SME's crucial role in supporting economic growth, and their adaptation and operational improvements contribute significantly to business resilience and community development. According to (Ramdan et al., 2022) SMEs are vital in creating jobs, fostering innovation, and ensuring fair income distribution, making them a cornerstone of local and national economic growth. Their flexibility and adaptability allow them to respond effectively to market changes, often fostering innovation and inclusive economic participation through continuous development of

resources and strategies. it demonstrates flexibility and adaptability that enable them to stay competitive and innovative amid changing market conditions, as explained by (Flaminiano, 2024).

Years in Business

The number of years an enterprise has been operating reflects its accumulated experience, market understanding, and adaptability to changing business environments. Mallinguh et al., (2020) noted that organizational experience, particularly years in business, significantly impacts SMEs' systems and decision-making. In the context of digital marketing, this factor helps assess how operational experience supports the adoption and execution of innovative marketing strategies. According to (Bermeo-Giraldo et al., 2022) SME age reflects the maturity and experience of a firm, often influencing its resource utilization and strategic decisions.

Amaya et al., (2024). states that years in business strengthen a firm's ability to adopt and execute innovative digital marketing strategies and added that SMEs with more years in business operations tend to establish a faster adaption to innovations that possess stable structures and clearer insights into customer behavior, strengthening their ability to implement digital marketing effectively. Maulida et al., (2025) concluded that firm age significantly influences growth and performance, indicating that established firms are better positioned to adopt and sustain innovative strategies such as digital marketing. Therefore, years in business serve as a key indicator of an enterprise's readiness to embrace digital transformation and maintain competitiveness in the modern marketplace.

Number of Employees

The number of employees refers to the total workforce size within an enterprise, serving as a basic measure of its operational scale and resource capacity. This variable is a vital indicator of an SME's ability to manage and sustain digital initiatives effectively (Michelotto & Joia, 2024). Firms with larger workforces often exhibit better-defined organizational systems and human resource capabilities, enabling them to

implement and maintain digital marketing strategies more efficiently (Joensuu-Salo et al., 2023). Conversely, smaller firms may rely on leaner teams that encourage agility and closer communication, fostering creativity and quicker adaptation to digital trends (Ahmed et al., 2022) The workforce size also influences the division of labor, technological training, and resource allocation, which directly affect the firm's marketing productivity and innovation potential (Sutherland et al., 2025). As noted by (Faiz et al., 2024)Employee strength plays a significant role in sustaining competitiveness by ensuring that SMEs can manage both operational and promotional demands in digital environments. Therefore, assessing the number of employees provides valuable insight into how human resource capacity impacts the adoption, implementation, and success of digital marketing within SMEs.

In conclusion, this review examined how digital marketing shapes the sustainability of SMEs, underscoring its growing importance in achieving competitiveness, innovation, and long-term growth. Guo et al., (2020) & Mishrif & Khan, (2023) asserted that adopting digital strategies enhances SME resilience and market responsiveness, while (Bürgel et al., 2023) & (Pingali et al., 2023) found that digital transformation drives efficiency and sustainable expansion. The review further identified that demographics, particularly years in business, number of employees, and digital capabilities, significantly affect SMEs' readiness to integrate digital marketing. As (Holl & Rama, 2024) explained, workforce size directly influences an SME's capacity to manage digital operations and marketing adoption, making it a crucial determinant of overall performance. Ahmed et al., (2025) noted that experienced firms adapt faster to technological shifts. El-Shihy & Hassan, (2025) stated that strong digital competence enables strategic advantage.

Nonetheless, challenges remain, (Adoro et al., 2024) highlighted that limited funding and digital literacy often slow adoption among smaller enterprises and indicated that various strategies, including SEO, social media, mobile, website ads, and email marketing are essential and cost-effective solution for these

problems. According to (Usmany et al., 2024) SEO boosts exposure and conversions, (Lim & Rasul, 2022) observed that social media builds consumer trust and brand recognition, while (Haudi et al., 2022) confirmed that mobile and email campaigns strengthen customer loyalty and direct engagement. Importantly, these tools are cost-effective and easy to operate, enabling SMEs to enhance marketing performance even with modest budgets. Lastly, sustainability measured through growth, audience reach, and customer satisfaction was identified as the key measurement of digital transformation. Digitalization accelerates business expansion and market reach (Rafidah et al., 2023). concluded that personalized digital experiences enhance satisfaction and long-term retention.

Digital Capabilities

Digital capabilities refer to an enterprise's ability to adopt, manage, and utilize digital tools and platforms for business operations and marketing purposes. Wulandari et al., (2024) emphasized that digital capability and the effective use of technological tools form the foundation for SME transformation and improved business performance. This factor is essential in assessing how equipped SMEs are to engage in digital marketing initiatives. Fang et al., (2024) stated that higher levels of digital technology, such as devices and stable internet access can enable SMEs to implement digital marketing strategies more effectively and maintain engagement in competitive environments. Amidst rapid digital change and rising competition, businesses can adapt to digital marketing strategies for long-term success by equipping cost-effective strategies such as social media, SEO, and mobile marketing to reach broader audiences and enhance performance (Maulida et al., 2025).

According to Olazo (2025), basic tools and skills, such as a mobile device and adequate internet access, are enough to operate a cost-effective digital marketing strategy. da Silva et al., (2025) demonstrated that SMEs with digital infrastructure and skills achieved higher productivity and market reach. Several studies emphasize that enhancing these capabilities promotes innovation, competitiveness,

and sustainability among SMEs, especially in rapidly changing digital environments. Al-Omush et al., 2023) confirmed that digital capability strengthens innovation and supports sustainable competitive performance among small and medium enterprises. Therefore, understanding the level of digital capability is vital in evaluating an SME's readiness to adapt and achieve long-term growth in the modern market. Anatan, (2023) also revealed that digital readiness and technological adaptation are crucial determinants of SME competitiveness and resilience in the digital economy.

Based on these findings, the present study seeks to determine whether digital marketing truly serves as an innovative strategy that sustains SMEs within BUENASCAR. While recent studies have shown digitalization's impact on business sustainability globally, there remains limited empirical evidence within the local context. Thus, this research aims to bridge that gap by examining how digital marketing contributes to the growth, customer satisfaction, and audience reach of SMEs in the area, testing whether these established insights hold in the local business environment.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

This study will be anchored on two main theories: The Dynamic Capabilities Theory (1997) and the Theory of Diffusion of Innovations (1962). These theories will provide the study with a vital understanding that highlights the need for firms to innovate and adapt to the modern method of marketing to gain an advantage in competition and ensure business continuity. The Diffusion of Innovations (DOI) Theory and the Dynamic Capabilities Theory were selected because they jointly explain both the adoption and the effective use of digital marketing among SMEs. DOI focuses on the perceptual and behavioral factors that influence whether firms decide to adopt an innovation, while the Dynamic Capabilities Theory explains how organizations develop the internal strengths needed to implement these innovations, adapt to changes, and sustain competitive advantage. Combined, they offer a comprehensive foundation for understanding why SMEs embrace digital marketing and how it contributes to long-term business sustainability.

Diffusion of Innovation (DOI) Theory

It highlights how new ideas, technologies, innovations, and practices span an organization. Popularized by Everett M. Rogers in the year 1962. The theory suggests that adoption is dependent on five factors, which are relative advantage, complexity, trialability, and observability (Patil et al., 2022), as used in their study entitled “Digital Marketing Adoption by Start-Ups and SMEs”. According to the study entitled “The Role of Social Media Utilization and Innovativeness on SMEs Performance” by (Subagja et al., 2022) This theory provides the advantage of the innovation compared to existing options, its compatibility with the values and needs of potential users, its level of complexity or ease of use, the degree of trialability or ability to be tested before full adoption, and the observability of its results to others.

These factors determine how quickly and widely an innovation will be accepted or rejected by individuals and groups. According to (Azizan & Mohammed Hardy Loh Rahim, 2024), the DOI theory provides a comprehensive framework for unraveling critical factors leading to technology adoption among

SMEs, especially among those in developing countries. Grounding on Diffusion of Innovation Theory Rogers, 1962, relative advantage, organizational readiness, security, and managerial characteristics are presupposed to have a positive effect on the intention to adopt online technology for SMEs (Grimaldo et al., 2023). DOI factors directly support digital-marketing adoption among SMEs because relative advantage reflects how digital platforms provide improved promotion, broader visibility, and better customer connection compared to traditional methods. Trialability and ease of use align with how SMEs can first explore social-media pages, online content, and mobile-based tools without major cost, allowing them to test what works before fully adopting the strategy. The observable outcomes—such as engagement, reach, and customer response—reinforce adoption as SMEs see clear results that support growth and sustainability.

Dynamic Capabilities Theory

Authored by Teece, Pisano, and Shuen 1997, it focuses on a firm's ability to adapt to rapidly changing environments by sensing opportunities, seizing them, and reconfiguring resources accordingly. A study titled *"The Influence of Technological and Marketing Capabilities on MSME Performance with Organizational Learning as a Mediating Variable"* (Ayu et al., 2025) noted that this theory emphasizes that in order to survive and remain competitive, businesses must continuously develop and adjust their internal processes and strategies.

"Boosting SMEs' digital transformation: the role of dynamic capabilities in cultivating digital leadership and digital culture" by (Held et al., 2025) highlights how innovation, such as adopting digital marketing, enables firms to respond effectively to market disruptions and ensure long-term business continuity. The theory suggests the foundations of competitive advantage) (Mittal & Kumar, 2024. (1) to sense and shape opportunities and threats, (2) to seize opportunities, and (3) to maintain competitiveness

through enhancing, combining, protecting, and, when necessary, reconfiguring the business enterprise's intangible and tangible assets (Tran et al., 2024)

By applying these theories, (a) Diffusion of Innovation Theory explains that the success of new ideas or technologies depends on how beneficial, compatible, simple, testable, and visible they are, showing that adoption is driven by both individual perceptions and social influence (Manurung & Ningsi, 2025), additionally the Dynamic Capability Theory (b) focuses on a firm's ability to adapt to rapidly changing environments by sensing opportunities, seizing them, and reconfiguring resources accordingly.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

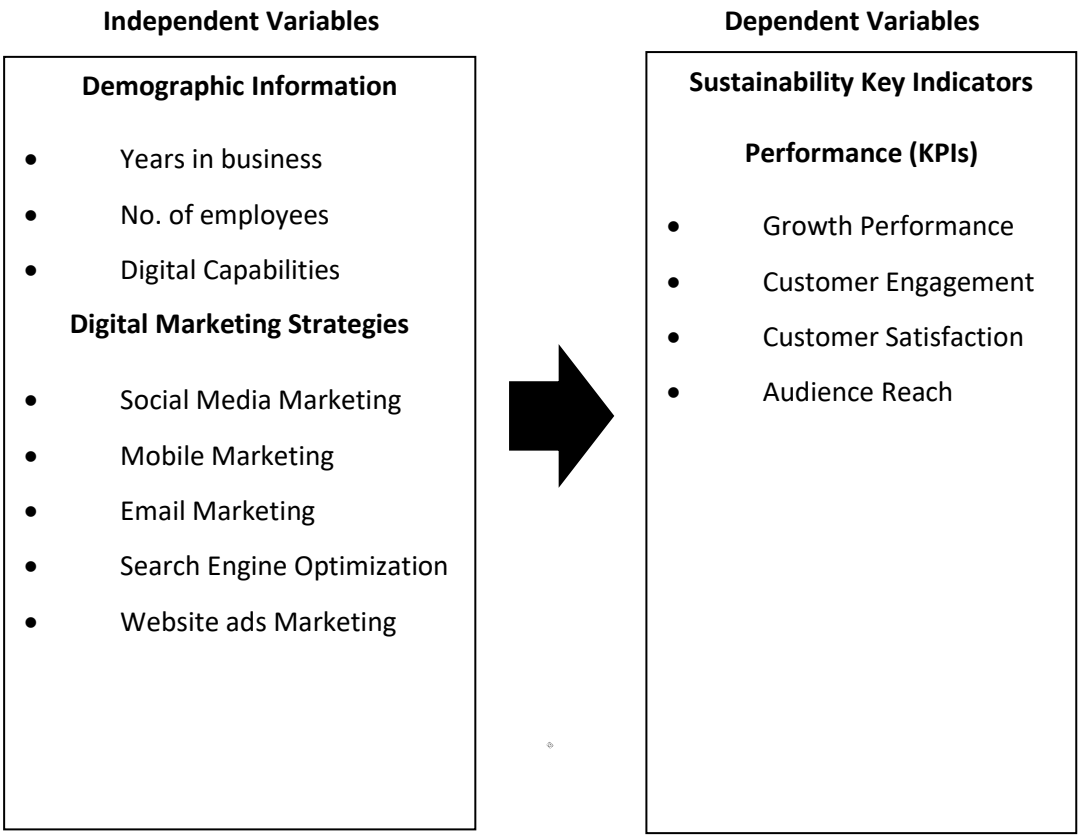


Figure 1. The Schematic Diagram illustrates the relationship between the study's independent and dependent variables.

1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study

The objective of the study is to determine digital marketing as an innovative strategy for sustainability among SMEs in BUENASCAR. Specifically, to address the following questions.

1. What is the profile of the respondents in terms of:

    1.1 Years in business:

    1.2 No. of employees; and

    1.3 Digital Capabilities?

2. To what extent are digital marketing strategies employed by SMEs in BUENASCAR in terms of:

    2.1 Social Media Marketing;

    2.2 Mobile Marketing;

    2.3 Email Marketing;

    2.4 Search Engine Optimization (SEO); and

    2.5 Website ads Marketing?

3. To what extent are the sustainability Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) among SMEs in BUENASCAR in terms of:

    3.1 Growth Performance:

    3.2 Customer engagement;

    3.3 Customer Satisfaction; and

    3.4 Audience Reach?

4. Is there a significant relationship between Digital marketing and sustainability Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) among SMEs in BUENASCAR?

1.6 Hypothesis

The hypothesis will guide this study.

H_o: There is no significant relationship between Digital Marketing as an innovative strategy and Sustainability key performance indicators (KPIs) among SMEs in BUENASCAR.

Scope and Limitation.

The study will focus on enterprises with a workforce size of 10-99 employees for small enterprises and 100-199 employees for medium enterprises based on the definition of the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI). This study is limited only to SMEs, excluding enterprises with below 10 and above 199 employees in their workforce size. It is also limited to enterprises operating within Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. It will also concentrate solely on digital marketing aspects, excluding other factors influencing SMEs performance.

1.7 Definition of Terms

For a better understanding and classification, the following terms and words are operationally defined as follows:

Customer Engagement. refers to the level of interaction and active response that customers show toward an SME's digital marketing activities across online platforms.

Customer Satisfaction. are the degree of happiness customers feels with an SME's products or services through its digital marketing.

Cost-Effective. refers to achieving desired results through digital marketing while minimizing business expenses.

Digital Marketing. the use of digital tools and channels to promote SME products and support sustainable growth, such as social media, mobile marketing, email marketing, and SEO.

Digital Capabilities. the technological assets SMEs apply in managing digital marketing strategies.

Email Marketing. sending promotional or informational emails to maintain customer engagement.

Employee. a worker who supports SME operations and digital activities.

Growth Performance. the increase in an SME's sales, reach, or revenue resulting from digital marketing strategies.

Innovation. The process of adopting new digital ideas or methods that strengthen SME's sustainability.

Key Performance Indicator (KPI). a set of measurements tracking SME results from digital marketing use.

Marketing. promoting SME products or services to meet customer needs through digital means.

Medium Enterprise. Privately owned local business with limited workforce specifically under the MSME sector, which consists of 100-199 employees as defined by the Department of Trade and Industry.

Mobile Marketing. refers to marketing strategies targeting SMEs' audiences via smartphones and tablets through SMS, apps, and mobile-optimized channels.

Strategy. a planned digital approach aimed at achieving SME's growth and sustainability.

Sustainability. the capacity of SMEs to maintain long-term operations through innovative digital efforts.

Search Engine Optimization (SEO). improving website visibility to increase online traffic for SMEs.

Social Media Marketing. using social platforms to advertise SME products and engage customers.

Small Enterprises. privately owned local businesses with limited workforce under the MSME sector, which consists of 10-99 as defined by the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI).

Website ads Marketing. refers to the strategic placement of online display ads and paid search ads on websites that SMEs use to attract potential customers and support their overall sustainability.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design

This study will use a quantitative, descriptive-correlational research design because it is appropriate for describing existing conditions and examining relationships between variables. The descriptive component allows the researchers to identify and describe the digital marketing strategies currently used by SMEs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BUENASCAR). The correlational component enables the study to determine whether a significant relationship exists between digital marketing strategies and SME sustainability performance without manipulating any variables, making it suitable for analyzing real-world business practices in the local setting.

2.2 Research Locale

This study will be conducted across three selected municipalities in Agusan del Norte—Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Buenavista has a land area of 475.61 square kilometers with a population of 68,892; Nasipit covers 144.40 square kilometers with a population of 44,822; while Carmen has a land area of 311.02 square kilometers and a population of 23,172, based on the 2020 census. These municipalities collectively form the BUENASCAR area, where numerous small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) operate across various industries.

The selection of these locations is justified by their shared local economic characteristics, where SMEs serve as key drivers of employment, trade, and community development. At the same time, these enterprises are increasingly challenged to adapt to digitalization to remain competitive. The combination of developing local markets and growing exposure to digital platforms makes the BUENASCAR area an appropriate setting for examining how SMEs use digital marketing as an innovative strategy for sustainability. Collectively, SMEs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen provide a representative local context

for assessing how digital marketing enhances business visibility, competitiveness, and long-term sustainability within the regional economy. Additionally, The SMEs in the BUENASCAR area were chosen because they are important to the local economy, providing jobs, services, and business activity in both rural and semi-urban communities. These local businesses represent the real conditions and challenges faced by enterprises outside big cities, making them good examples of how digital marketing supports sustainability and competitiveness. This study looks at how digital marketing tools—such as social media marketing, mobile marketing, email marketing, website marketing, and SEO—help improve growth performance, customer satisfaction, customer engagement, and audience reach.

2.3 Research Respondents

SMEs from Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, represented by their respective owners or managers, are selected as respondents because they have direct oversight of business operations and strategic decisions. As the primary decision-makers, they are most knowledgeable about their enterprises' marketing practices, including the adoption of digital marketing strategies, and are therefore capable of providing accurate and reliable information relevant to the study on sustainability.

Cluster sampling and availability and convenience are methodologically incompatible. Cluster sampling is a probability sampling method while convenience sampling is non-probability method. The researchers will collect data from answered questionnaires through an actual setting. The researchers already got permission from the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen to conduct an acquisition of information on their SMEs, and therefore, to determine the required sample size for the study, Slovin's formula was applied at a five percent (5%) margin of error.

Thus, the required sample size is sixty-four (64) respondents, proportionally allocated to each location according to population share.

Table 1. Population and Sample Distribution

	Population			Total	Sample Size			Total	%
Respondents	Buenavista	Nasipit	Carmen		Buenavista	Nasipit	Carmen		
Small	28	26	18	72	23	22	15	**60**	**93.75%**
Medium	2	2	0	4	2	2	0	**4**	**6.25%**
TOTAL	**30**	**28**	**18**	**76**	**25**	**24**	**15**	**64**	**100%**

The table presents the population and sample distribution of seventy-six (76) Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) across the locations of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Using Slovin's formula at a five percent (5%) margin of error, the computed total sample size is sixty-four (64) respondents. The sample was proportionally allocated across the three areas, ensuring that each location's share of respondents reflects its actual SME population. Buenavista, with thirty (30) enterprises, Nasipit with twenty-eight (28), and Carmen with eighteen (18), each received sample allocations based on their respective population sizes. This proportional distribution guarantees fair and representative coverage of both small and medium enterprises within the selected municipalities.

The selection of SMEs for this study was guided by the employee-based classification of the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI), which identifies small enterprises as those employing 10–99 workers and medium enterprises as those with 100–199 workers. Using workforce size as the primary criterion ensures that the enterprises included fall squarely within the nationally recognized SME category. This approach is consistent with recent regional research, particularly the study conducted in Butuan City by (Modar, Herrera, and Alerta, 2023), who likewise classified SMEs based on employee count when examining innovation-related practices.

Following this standard, SMEs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen were selected solely based on their employee size. The study intentionally excluded capital and revenue criteria, as requesting such financial information is highly confidential and may cause discomfort among respondents. Like the method employed by (Modar, Herrera, and Alerta, 2023), relying on workforce size provides a reliable, ethical, and non-intrusive basis for SME classification while safeguarding respondent privacy and trust.

Meanwhile, the exclusion criteria will rule out micro enterprises and other business entities with a workforce size below 10 employees and those with above 199 employees, as it does not meet the official definition of SMEs based on DTI, as well as those unwilling to take part in the study. These criteria were thoughtfully designed to ensure that the chosen respondents genuinely represent the SME sector within the selected areas, providing credible insights into how digital marketing serves as an innovative strategy for sustaining business growth and competitiveness. This study will investigate digital marketing as an innovative strategy for sustainability among SMEs in BUENASCAR. It will use a cluster and random sampling approach. The study will focus on enterprises with a workforce size of 10-99 employees for small enterprises and 100-199 employees for medium enterprises based on the definition of the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI). This study is limited only to SMEs, excluding enterprises with below 10 and above 199 employees in their workforce size. It is also limited to enterprises operating within Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. It will also concentrate solely on digital marketing aspects, excluding other factors influencing SMEs performance.

The SMEs in the BUENASCAR area were chosen because they are important to the local economy, providing jobs, services, and business activity in both rural and semi-urban communities. These local businesses represent the real conditions and challenges faced by enterprises outside big cities, making them good examples of how digital marketing supports sustainability and competitiveness. This study looks at how digital marketing tools—such as social media marketing, mobile marketing, email marketing,

website marketing, and SEO—help improve growth performance, customer satisfaction, customer engagement, and audience reach.

2.4 Research Instrument

The study adopts and refines established research instruments from previous empirical studies to ensure their suitability for the local Small and Medium Enterprise (SME) context. The questionnaire is based on the works of Kamithi Rosemary Mugure (2022), "Influence of Social Media Marketing on Performance of Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises in Downtown Central Business District, Nairobi," Rahman (2023), "Impact of Social Media Marketing on Consumer Purchase Action: A Case Study of SME Consumers in Bangladesh," and Olazo (2022), "Measuring the Level of Digital Marketing Capabilities, Digital Marketing Strategies, and Challenges and Issues of SMEs in Adopting Digital Marketing." These studies examined how digital and online marketing practices affect business performance, consumer behavior, and sustainability among SMEs.

The instruments were carefully reviewed and modified to align with the objectives of the present study entitled "Digital Marketing: Innovative Strategy for Sustainability Among SMEs in Buenascar." Revisions were made to reflect the local business setting and to accurately measure digital marketing capabilities, digital marketing strategies, and sustainability key performance indicators (KPIs) relevant to SMEs in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte.

To ensure the validity and reliability of the research instrument, the questionnaire will undergo content validation by subject matter experts, including the research adviser and panel members. Their assessment will focus on the clarity, relevance, and alignment of each item with the study objectives. Suggested revisions will be incorporated to improve the overall quality of the instrument. After content validation, a pilot test will be conducted among 30 SME owners or managers who share similar characteristics with the target respondents but are not included in the final sample. The pilot test aims to

identify unclear items and evaluate the consistency of responses. The results will be analyzed to assess the reliability of the instrument, particularly its internal consistency. Necessary revisions will be made before the final administration of the questionnaire. The primary data collection tool will be a structured survey questionnaire administered to SME owners or managers in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte.

The questionnaire is designed to gather quantitative data on the level of digital marketing adoption and its role as an innovative strategy for SME sustainability. A four-point Likert scale will be used to measure respondents' agreement with each statement, where 4 represents Strongly Agree, 3 Agree, 2 Disagree, and 1 Strongly Disagree.

The questionnaire consists of four parts:

Part I. collects information on the respondents' business profile, including years of operation, number of employees, and level of digital capabilities.

Part II. examines digital marketing approaches used by SMEs, such as social media marketing, mobile marketing, email marketing, website advertising, and search engine optimization (SEO).

Part III. assesses SME sustainability using key performance indicators, including growth performance, customer satisfaction, customer engagement, and audience reach.

Part IV. examines the relationship between digital marketing practices and the sustainability key performance indicators of SMEs.

Through these procedures, the study ensures that the research instrument is valid, reliable, and appropriate for measuring digital marketing practices and sustainability outcomes among SMEs in the local setting.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

This research, entitled *"Digital Marketing as an Innovative Strategy for Sustainability among SMEs in BUENASCAR,"* adheres to the highest ethical principles to ensure research integrity, respect for participants, and compliance with institutional and professional standards.

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

The study safeguards all intellectual property rights associated with its conduct. The research instruments, specifically the survey questionnaires, are adopted and modified by the researchers. All sources of information, concepts, and materials utilized in the study were properly cited and acknowledged in accordance with copyright regulations. No patented or trademarked materials were used without authorization, ensuring full compliance with intellectual property laws.

B. Informed Consent

Prior to data collection, the selected SME owners or representatives will be formally informed through a written informed-consent form that clearly explains the purpose of the study, the procedures involved, and the voluntary nature of their participation. The researchers will personally explain the contents of the consent form to ensure full understanding before participation. Written consent will then be obtained, and respondents will be informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any time without any penalty or disadvantage.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The study strictly observed data privacy and confidentiality standards. All personal and business information obtained from participants was treated with utmost discretion and anonymity. Data were securely stored in password-protected systems accessible only to the researchers and their research adviser, who also serves as a co-author of the study. Any sharing of data, even in anonymized form, required explicit participant consent.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

Participation in this study was entirely voluntary without any renumeration ensuring that they are participating without any relationship to the researchers. The researchers ensured that no coercion or undue influence affected the participants' decision to join. Participants retained the right to discontinue their involvement at any point, with assurance that their withdrawal would not result in any adverse consequences.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

The researchers exercised diligence to prevent any physical, psychological, or professional harm to the participants. Data collection was conducted in a respectful, non-intrusive, and secure environment, which the researcher allows the participants answer the survey questionnaire in their own discreet environment. All discussions and inquiries avoided sensitive business information that could potentially compromise participants' interests.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

This study aims to advance understanding of how digital marketing can enhance the sustainability of SMEs, contributing both to academic discourse and practical business strategies. The findings are expected to provide actionable insights that promote innovation and competitiveness among local enterprises. Participants may request access to the study's results for their own professional or organizational use.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

The selection of participants followed fair and transparent inclusion criteria. SME owners and representatives from various industries and business sizes within the region were randomly chosen to ensure diverse perspectives. No discrimination based on gender, age, socioeconomic status, or business category occurred in the selection process.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

To uphold the validity and reliability of the study, the researchers employed standardized data collection and analysis procedures. Data were verified, analyzed systematically, and interpreted objectively to ensure accuracy and consistency. Every effort was made to minimize researcher bias and maintain alignment with the study's objectives.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The researchers are committed to full transparency in reporting the research process and outcomes. All data, methods, and results are presented accurately and honestly. Any errors, limitations, or challenges encountered during the research were disclosed to maintain integrity and credibility. Both favorable and unfavorable results were included to ensure balanced reporting.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

The researchers obtained proper authorization for any copyrighted or licensed material incorporated into the study. All external works were cited in accordance with APA 7th edition guidelines and institutional citation standards. No restricted or unauthorized materials were reproduced or distributed.

K. Ethical Considerations for Human Participants

The research involved only human participants, specifically SME owners and representatives. All participants were treated with dignity, fairness, and respect. They were thoroughly informed of the study's objectives, expected benefits, and their rights as participants. Confidentiality and anonymity were strictly maintained throughout the research process.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technologies

Artificial intelligence tools, such as ChatGPT and Grammarly, were responsibly utilized to enhance the clarity and grammatical accuracy of the manuscript. The researchers retained full control over data

interpretation and analysis, ensuring that AI tools were employed ethically and only for linguistic and formatting assistance, not for analytical decision-making.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Before data collection, ethical clearance was secured from the Ethics Review Committee of Saint Michael College of Caraga. The researchers strictly adhered to all institutional, national, and ethical protocols governing research involving human participants. All instruments, procedures, and consent forms were reviewed and approved to ensure compliance with ethical research standards.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure

Prior to the conduct of the study, approval will be secured from the research adviser and the Dean of the College. Upon approval, formal permission letters will be prepared and distributed to selected Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. These letters will request authorization to administer the survey questionnaire to SME owners and managers, who are directly involved in overseeing overall business operations and decision-making.

Ethical clearance will also be obtained from Saint Michael College of Caraga to ensure that all research activities comply with institutional and ethical standards. This approval process ensures that the rights, welfare, and privacy of all respondents are adequately protected throughout the duration of the study.

Before the distribution of the questionnaires, respondents will be given a brief orientation regarding the purpose of the study, the nature of their participation, and the procedures involved. The orientation will emphasize that participation is voluntary and that respondents may decline or withdraw at any point without any consequences.

Informed consent form will be provided to each respondent prior to participation. The consent form will explain the objectives of the study, the type of information to be collected, measures taken to

ensure confidentiality, and the respondents' right to withdraw at any time. Only those who voluntarily provide consent will be included in the study.

The respondents will be selected using random sampling. The sample size will be determined using Slovin's formula to ensure that the number of participants is representative of the SME population in the selected municipalities. This sampling approach aims to reduce bias and allow for fair representation of SMEs across different industries.

Data will be collected through a structured survey questionnaire printed and personally distributed to SME owners and managers. After completion, the questionnaires will be retrieved by the researchers. All responses will be checked for completeness and clarity, and incomplete or unclear entries will be addressed, when possible, to maintain data quality.

Collected data will be encoded, organized, and analyzed using appropriate statistical tools. Descriptive statistics will be used to summarize the profile of respondents and the level of digital marketing adoption, while correlational analysis will be employed to determine the relationship between digital marketing practices and sustainability indicators among SMEs.

All collected data will be stored in passcode-protected digital files accessible only to the researcher and the research adviser, who is also a co-author of the study. No third party will have access to the data without written consent from the respondents. Upon completion of the study, all electronic data will be securely deleted to prevent unauthorized access and ensure confidentiality.

Throughout the research process, ethical principles such as voluntary participation, confidentiality, and anonymity will be strictly observed. All information gathered will be used solely for academic and research purposes, ensuring the protection of respondents' rights and the integrity of the study.

2.7 Data Analysis Plan and Procedure

Statistical Treatment

This study employs appropriate statistical tools to systematically analyze and interpret the data gathered from the respondents. The statistical treatment is designed to ensure accurate, objective, and meaningful analysis in addressing the research problems and determining the relationship between digital marketing strategies and the sustainability of SMEs in the BUENASCAR area.

Percentage and Frequency.

This will be used to describe the demographic profile of the SMEs in BUENASCAR, specifically focusing on their years in business, number of employees, and level of digital capabilities. These measures will summarize the distribution of respondents and provide a clear understanding of their organizational characteristics.

Weighted Mean.

This will be used to answer Problem 2, which seeks to determine the extent of digital marketing strategies employed by SMEs in BUENASCAR in terms of social media marketing, mobile marketing, website ads marketing, email marketing, and search engine optimization (SEO).

It will also address Problem 3, which measures the extent of the sustainability Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) among SMEs in terms of growth perf2ormance, customer engagement, customer satisfaction, and audience reach.

Pearson's r Correlation.

This will be employed to answer Problem 4, which examines whether there is a significant relationship between digital marketing strategies and the sustainability Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) among SMEs in BUENASCAR. This statistical test will determine the strength and direction of the relationship between the independent and dependent variables.

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